

**UNIT
6**

ARTICLES

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22 ARTICLES – "A," "AN," AND "THE"

A. Introduction to Articles

Articles in English include the definite article "the" and the indefinite articles "a" and "an." These are used to define whether a noun is specific or nonspecific.

B. Using "a" and "an" (Indefinite Articles)

Indefinite articles are used when referring to general items, not specific ones.

- "A" is used before words beginning with a consonant sound:

- **Example:** A dog, a balloon, a car.

- "An" is used before words beginning with a vowel sound:

- **Example:** An apple, an orange, an umbrella.

C. Specific Uses of "The" (Definite Article)

The definite article **"the"** is used to refer to specific items that are known to the speaker and the listener, or have been previously mentioned.

1. Referring to something known to both the speaker and listener:

- **Example:** Can you turn off **the** light? (Both know which light is being referred to)

2. Referring to something previously mentioned:

- **Example:** She bought a cat and a dog. **The** cat is friendly, but **the** dog is not.

3. With superlatives and ordinal numbers:

- **Example:** He is **the** best player on the team. She arrived **the** first.

4. With objects considered to be unique:

- **Example:** **The** Sun, **the** Earth, **the** Moon.

5. Before singular nouns that represent a whole class or species:

- **Example:** **The** whale is an endangered species.

6. With geographical locations like rivers, seas, mountain ranges, deserts, and points on the globe:

- **Example:** **The** Nile, **the** Himalayas, **the** Sahara, **the** North Pole.

7. With decades or groups of years:

- **Example:** She grew up in **the** eighties.

8. With musical instruments when referred to in general:

- **Example:** He can play **the** guitar.

9. With newspapers, well-known buildings or works of art:

- **Example:** She reads **the** Guardian. They visited **the** Louvre.

Study this example:

- Zain: I had a sandwich and an apple for lunch. The sandwich wasn't very good, but the apple was nice.

Zain says 'a sandwich,' 'an apple' because this is the first time he talks about them. Zain now says 'the sandwich,' 'the apple' because we know which sandwich and which apple he means – the sandwich and the apple he had for lunch.

Compare **a** and **the** in these examples:

- A man and a woman were sitting opposite me. The man was American, but I think **the woman** was British.
- When we were on holiday, we stayed at **a hotel**. Sometimes we ate at **the hotel** and sometimes we went to **a restaurant**.

We use **the** when we are thinking of a specific thing.

Compare **a/an** and **the**:

- Tim sat down on a chair. (maybe one of many chairs in the room)
- Tim sat down on the chair nearest the door. (a specific chair)
- Do you have a car? (not a specific car)
- I cleaned the car yesterday. (= my car)

D. Omission of Articles

In some contexts, English does not use articles before nouns. Here are situations where articles are generally omitted:

1. Before names of languages and academic subjects:

- **Example:** She is studying **mathematics**. He can speak **French**.

2. Before names of meals, unless attributive adjectives make them specific:

- **Example:** They have breakfast at eight. She invited me to **a** delicious dinner.

3. Before names of cities, countries, continents, or individual mountains:

- **Example:** They travelled from **Berlin** to **Asia** via **Mount Fuji**.

4. Before nouns indicating places but used in a general sense:

- **Example:** He goes to college. She was sent to prison.

5. Before most proper nouns, including people's names, brand names, or companies:

- **Example:** Laila, Coca-Cola, and Microsoft do not require an article.

6. We also use **Earth** (without the) when we think of it as a planet in space (like Mars, Jupiter etc.):

- Which is the planet nearest **Earth**?

7. We say **space** (without the) when we mean 'space in the universe'.

Compare:

- There are millions of stars in **space**. (not in the space)
- I tried to park my car, but **the space** was too small.

8. We usually say **breakfast/lunch/dinner** (without the):

- What did you have for **breakfast**?
- We had **lunch** in a very nice restaurant.

But we say '**a big lunch**, a wonderful dinner,' '**an early breakfast**' etc.:

- We had **a very nice lunch**. (not We had very nice lunch)

Exercise: 1

Put in a/an or the.

1. This morning I bought _____ book and _____ magazine. _____ book is in my bag, but I can't remember where I put _____ magazine.
2. I saw _____ accident this morning. _____ car crashed _____ tree. _____ driver of _____ car wasn't hurt, but _____ car was badly damaged.
3. There are two cars parked outside: _____ blue one and _____ grey one. _____ blue one belongs to my neighbours. I don't know who _____ owner of _____ grey one is.
4. My friends live in _____ old house in _____ small village. There is _____ beautiful garden behind _____ house. I would like to have _____ garden like that.
5. _____ Sun is a star.
6. I'm fed up with doing _____ same thing every day.
7. Room 25 is on _____ second floor.
8. It was very hot day. It was _____ hottest day of year.

9. We had lunch in _____ nice restaurant by sea.

10. What's on at _____ cinema this week?

Exercise: 2

Put in "the" or "a" where necessary. If no word is necessary, leave the space empty.

1. **A:** Our apartment is on _____ tenth floor.

B: Is it? I hope there's _____ lift.

2. **A:** Did you have _____ nice holiday?

B: Yes, it was _____ best holiday I've ever had.

3. **A:** Where's _____ nearest shop?

B: There's one at _____ end of this street.

4. **A:** It's a lovely day, isn't it?

B: Yes, there isn't _____ cloud in _____ sky.

5. **A:** We spent all our money because we stayed at _____ most expensive hotel in town.

B: Why didn't you stay at _____ cheaper hotel?

6. **A:** Would you like to travel in _____ rocket?

B: Yes, I'd love to go to _____ moon.

7. **A:** What did you think of _____ movie last night?

B: It was OK, but I thought _____ ending was a bit strange.

8. **A:** What's Jupiter? Is it _____ star?

B: No, it's _____ planet. It's _____ largest planet in _____ solar system.

Exercise: 3

Fill in "a," "an," "the," or no article.

a. This house is very nice. Does it have _____ garden?

b. It's a beautiful day. Let's sit in _____ garden.

c. I like living in this house, but it's a shame that _____ garden is so small.

2. Can you recommend _____ good restaurant?

~We had dinner in _____ very nice restaurant.

~We had dinner in _____ best restaurant in town.

3. What's _____ name of that man we met yesterday?

4. We stayed at _____ very nice hotel – I can't remember _____ name now.

5. My neighbour has _____ French name, but in fact she's English, not French.
6. Did Alia get _____ job she applied for? It's not easy to get _____ job at the moment.
7. Ali has a part-time job. He works three mornings _____ week.
8. Last night, I watched _____ movie. _____ movie was thrilling.
9. I need _____ apple from that basket.
10. She plays _____ piano beautifully.
11. He was _____ first to arrive at _____ party.
12. There is _____ book on _____ table that you should read.
13. Can you see _____ moon in _____ sky tonight?
14. We visited _____ old castle in _____ mountains.
15. My brother wants to be _____ engineer when he grows up.

Exercise: 4

Decide whether to use "a," "an," "the," or no article

1. _____ Sun rises in _____ east.
2. I bought _____ new shoes yesterday; _____ shoes are very comfortable.
3. _____ honesty is best policy.
4. _____ Everest is _____ highest mountain in _____ world.
5. They are studying _____ Spanish.
6. _____ water boils at 100 degrees Celsius.
7. She has _____ interest in learning _____ Japanese.
8. We had _____ great time at _____ concert last night.
9. _____ Nile is _____ longest river in _____ world.
10. He found _____ wallet on _____ ground near _____ school.
11. They are looking for _____ house to rent near _____ city centre.
12. _____ teacher asked us to open _____ windows in _____ classroom.